



CHOPRA (LEFT) AND GAUTAM GAMBHIR DURING THE RANJI FINALS PLAYED TO EMPTY STANDS

All Round VIEW

The first Indian diary about a cricketer's life outside the glare of the international game

| By Sharda Ugra |

Much about *Beyond the Blues* is a first: an Indian domestic cricket season has never been so intimately documented (nor, mind you, has an international season) and never before has an Indian cricketer put a diary out into the public domain which talks about the game, his game and his life on the margins of our great national obsession.

Aakash Chopra, former India opener, was once out there in the white-hot heart of international competition. In 2004-05, he fronted the Indian innings with Virender Sehwag, batted with distinction and courage on tour in Australia, a key character in a series now acknowledged as the tipping point in India's improved performances away from home. Dropped the following season, Chopra had to retreat to the anonymous world that is Indian domestic cricket and set about trying to return to the big league. During weeks playing league cricket in England, he wrote a series of off-beat newspaper columns about life as an itinerant

cricketer, which in its own way, led to this diary.

Beyond the Blues sounds and reads like as it is meant to: a first-person conversational. It is part description of the ebb and flow of cricket matches and part foray into what it feels like inside Indian domestic cricket—that little-known, unglamorous circuit of a game considered glamorous. Where cricket is played out in the shadow of the glare, yet still contains all the elements of the sport's great human drama.

Season after season, domestic cricket heaves with ambition and resignation, cynicism and hope. It contains enduring characters: the old, smart pros, the disoriented "discards" (one of the most cruel words in the vocabulary of our cricket press, often deliberately used to ridicule those left out from the Indian team), the burnouts and the hot, young chosen ones.

Every season, at the end of six months of living out of each others' pockets, one such disparate group plays enough tough cricket to become India's national champions. In 2007-08, as Chopra travelled through Dharamshala and Nagothane, struck the form of his life, piled up nearly 1,700 runs and grumbled about buses and umpires, the team that emerged champs was his own: Delhi, after a gap of 16 years.

Beyond the Blues is a reflection of all that is Indian domestic cricket but also the diarist himself. The eye that notices more than the playing field, the mind for detail and a sense of humour, which has made surviving the treadmill slightly easier than it probably is. Chopra's narrative crackles with honesty and a lack of self-consciousness. He tells you exactly what it felt like to be ignored for India's last tour to Australia and about the time fielders heard the square leg umpire talking on his mobile phone during a match.

In between the summaries of a day's play come insights: revealing character-sketches of teammates, the dynamics of a dressing room, the arrogance of officialdom, the insecurities that forever gnaw at the edges of cricketers' personalities.

First-class cricket all over the world has its own folklore and Chopra's book has added to India's; in fact, it has in all likelihood have inaugurated the genre in this country. Though it must be said, few cricketers could spend the day baking in the sun and the evening labouring away on MS Word—as a rule would rather watch a movie or kill time on Facebook. That, in itself, makes *Beyond the Blues* exceptional. ■



BEYOND THE BLUES

by AAKASH CHOPRA

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